

Day 8 — Tirthaji and Historical Context

Module: ×11 Multiplication — Ekādhikena Pūrveṇa · **Band:** Senior · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students will: explain who tirthaji was and why scholars debate the “vedic” attribution.

Materials

- Whiteboard / chart paper
- Notebook, pen per student
- (See lesson-plan.md for any day-specific materials)

Vocabulary introduced today

- *sūtra* (IAST: sūtra; lit. “aphorism / formula”)

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily check-in: one-sentence response to “*What’s one thing you remember about yesterday’s lesson?*”
- Hook: introduce a phenomenon or question that motivates today’s concept.

Core (20 min)

1. **Who was Tirthaji?** Bharati Krishna Tirthaji (1884–1960), Śaṅkarācārya of Govardhana Maṭha, Puri. Composed the manuscript that became *Vedic Mathematics* during 1911–1918. Published posthumously 1965.
2. **Tirthaji’s claim.** The 16 sūtras + 13 sub-sūtras were “reconstructed” from the *Parīśiṣṭa of the Atharva Veda*. The original manuscript with sūtras has never been independently located.
3. **Scholarly response.** S.G. Dani (Tata Institute of Fundamental Research), in *Frontline* (1993), examined the claim: the sūtras as published do NOT appear in extant Atharva Veda Parīśiṣṭa manuscripts. Most academic mathematicians treat Tirthaji’s system as a 20th-century mental-arithmetic synthesis, drawing on traditional and modern sources, NOT strictly ancient mathematics.
4. **Pedagogical value.** The methods themselves work and teach number sense effectively. The *historical claim* is separable from the *pedagogical method*. Many curricula in India today teach the methods while updating the historical claim.
5. **Reading.** Hand out a one-page excerpt from Dani’s article and Tirthaji’s preface side-by-side. Pairs discuss: “*What does each author claim? What evidence does each provide?*”

Activity (15 min)

A scaled version of *Mental Math Sprint Cards* (see [activities/](#)). Today's slice: focus on the part of the activity that reinforces Tirthaji and Historical Context.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- One-sentence exit ticket: “*What’s one thing you learned today?*”
- Preview tomorrow.

Homework

(See `homework.md` for today’s task.)

Differentiation

- **Extension:** offer one open question or extra problem for fast finishers.
- **Support:** pair students who need scaffolds; offer partial outlines.

Teacher notes

- Citations: at least one quoted verse with citation per module. Day 1 already includes one if applicable; you may add more.
- Connect to prior modules where natural (especially Module 2 *pañcabhūta*).